



ARIAS SOCIETY

Assam Rural Infrastructure and Agricultural Services Society

(An Autonomous Body of the Govt. of Assam)

**Project Management Unit (PMU) of the Asian Development Financed
Assam Sustainable Wetland and Integrated Fisheries Transformation (SWIFT) Project**

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Grievance Redressal Mechanism (GRM) Manual

For

**ADB assisted Assam Sustainable
Wetland and Integrated Fisheries
Transformation (SWIFT) Project**



Grievance Redressal Mechanism (GRM) Manual

Assam Sustainable Wetland and Integrated Fisheries Transformation (SWIFT) Project

1. Introduction and Objective

In accordance with the Asian Development Bank (ADB) Safeguard Policy Statement (2009) and the principles of transparency, accountability, and inclusiveness, the Sustainable Wetland and Integrated Fisheries Transformation (SWIFT) Project has established a robust Grievance Redressal Mechanism (GRM).

The GRM aims to provide a structured, accessible, and time-bound platform for receiving, assessing, and resolving grievances related to project planning, implementation, environmental and social safeguards, livelihood impacts, access to project benefits, and institutional arrangements. The mechanism is applicable throughout the project cycle and ensures that grievances are addressed fairly, promptly, and transparently.

The SWIFT Project is managed by ARIAS Society (an autonomous body of the Government of Assam) and implemented by the Directorate of Fisheries, Government of Assam, with financial assistance from the Asian Development Bank (ADB).

2. Guiding Principles of the GRM

The GRM is guided by the following core principles:

2.1 Transparency

The GRM promotes open communication and disclosure. Information on grievance procedures, timelines, and decisions shall be widely disseminated. Complainants shall be informed about the status and outcome of their grievances in a timely manner.

2.2 Social Inclusion

The mechanism is inclusive, gender-sensitive, and culturally appropriate. It ensures equitable access for women, Scheduled Tribes (STs), Scheduled Castes (SCs), vulnerable and marginalized groups, and other project-affected persons.

2.3 Simplicity and Accessibility

Procedures for lodging grievances are simple and easy to understand, including for non-literate persons. Multiple entry points—both online and offline—are provided to ensure universal access.

2.4 Confidentiality and Anonymity

The identity of complainants shall be kept confidential, particularly in sensitive cases. Anonymous grievances shall also be accepted and processed.

2.5 Institutional Strengthening

The GRM strengthens institutional accountability and communication between communities and project authorities, contributing to improved project implementation.

3. Scope and Applicability

The GRM shall be applicable to the following stakeholders:

- Project Affected Persons (PAPs)
- Beel-dependent communities
- Beel Development Committee (BDC) members

- Fisher cooperatives, Self-Help Groups (SHGs)
- Vulnerable groups including women, SCs, STs, and landless households
- Any stakeholder with a legitimate grievance related to the SWIFT Project

4. **Types/Classification of Grievances**

Grievances may include, but are not limited to:

- Institutional and governance-related issues
- Financial matters and benefit-sharing concerns
- Environmental and natural resource use impacts
- Quality of infrastructure and construction
- Social inclusion and safeguard-related issues
- Non-performance of project obligations
- Complaints against project staff or service providers
- Allegations of corruption, misconduct, or legal violations
- Suggestions and feedback

5. **Modes/Channels for Submission of Grievances**

Grievances may be submitted free of cost through the following channels:

Offline Modes

- Verbal or written complaints to field staff or beel animators
- Entry in grievance registers at project sites or offices
- Complaint/suggestion drop-boxes at project locations
- Written applications submitted in person or by post

Online Modes

- Project web platform for GRM (being developed)
- Email communication to CPIU/PIU/PMU
- Telephone or electronic submissions

Each grievance shall be acknowledged and assigned a unique tracking number.

6. **Institutional Arrangement for GRM**

A three-tier Grievance Redressal Committee (GRC) system shall be operational throughout the project duration.

6.1 Level I: Field / Community Level GRC

Constituted by: District Fisheries Development Officer (DFDO)

Composition:

- DFDO / SWIFT Nodal Officer – Chairperson
- BDC Facilitator (NGO) – Convenor
- Social Safeguards & Gender Coordinator – Member

- Representative of Fisher Cooperative/SHG/ST – Member
- Village Head / Autonomous Council Representative – Member
- Beel Animator – Rapporteur

Timeline for Resolution: Within 7 days of receipt

6.2 Level II: Cluster / CPIU Level GRC

Constituted by: Zonal Project Coordinator

Composition:

- Zonal Officer, CPIU – Chairperson
- DFDO – Convenor
- Local NGO representative / person of repute – Member
- ST community representative (preferably woman) – Member
- Social Safeguards / Environment Coordinator – Rapporteur

Timeline for Resolution: Within 15 days of receipt from Level I

6.3 Level III: PIU Level GRC

Composition:

- Deputy Project Director, SWIFT – Chairperson
- Social Safeguards & Gender Specialist – Convenor
- Senior Project Advisor (PMU) – Member
- PIU Representative – Member
- Communication Specialist – Rapporteur

Timeline for Resolution: Within 15 days of receipt from Level II

Gender Requirement: At least 30% of GRC members at each level shall be women.

7. Grievance Handling Protocol for Processing and Timelines

- Receipt and registration of grievance checked through all channels for submission of grievances within 2 working days
- Submission of acknowledgement letter to complainant once the complaint received
- Assign a Unique Tracking ID
- Preliminary screening for GRM scope applicability
- Screen for sensitivity/conflict of interest
- Hearing and resolution at appropriate GRC level
- Communication of decision to complainant in writing (Impartial investigation and decision-making shall be adhered) within 7 (1st level) to 15 days (2nd and 3rd levels)
- Escalation to higher level if unresolved or if complainant is dissatisfied to (following the action listed above from 1 to 7)
- Capture satisfaction feedback after closure
- Record all actions in GRM Register and PMIS

All actions shall be documented in prescribed formats.

Service Standards for manual/ online Channel			
Level of addressing grievance	Action to be taken	Responsibility	Timeline
First level – Site/ Sub-project/ Beel level	1. Grievance are received and registered manually/ email/ drop-box on the grievance redressal register with a Sl. No.	Beel Animator	Within 2 working days of receipt of grievances
	2. Submission of acknowledgement letter to complainant once the complaint received	Beel Animator	
	3. Prior to registering the grievance, a procedural step will be in place to assess and check that the issues raised in the complaint fall within the scope that the GRM is mandated to address.	Beel animator & BDC facilitator	
	4. If the grievance falls within the scope of the SWIFT GRM, the same shall be forwarded to the respective SSGC of concerned CPIU who will appraise the GRC Chairperson about the matter	BDC facilitator	
	5. Call for a meeting for addressing the grievance	BDC facilitator	
	6. Addressing the grievance	Grievance Redressal Committee-I	Within 7 days of receipt of grievance
	7. Communicating the grievance resolution with the complainant	Social Safeguards & Gender Coordinator (SSGC)	Within 7 days of receipt of grievance
	8. Grievances that cannot be resolved at the site level within 7 days or in cases where the complainant is not satisfied with the decision, will be referred to the CPIU-level (2 nd level) GRC		Within 10 days of receipt of grievance
	9. A Grievance Register will be maintained at the site level by Beel animator and s/he will register the grievance as per the prescribed format in Annexure I, including details of the date, type of grievance received, date of personal hearing, redressal process, redressal date, and if not redressed, the date of forwarding the grievance to the next level GRC.	Beel Animator	
Second level –Cluster level	10. Addressing the grievance.	GRC	Within 15 days of receiving the grievance from the GRC 1 st level
	11. Sending reply of the grievance to the aggrieved person with a copy of information to the chairperson of the 1 st level GRC	SSGC	
	If cannot be addressed at the cluster level, forward to PIU	SSGC	
	12. In case of forwarding as mentioned above in Sl. No. 9, reasons for not addressing the grievance at second level are explained.	SSGC	
Third level - PIU	13. Addressing the grievance.	Social Safeguards Specialist	Within 15 days of receiving the grievance from the
	14. Sending reply of the grievance to the aggrieved person with a copy of information to chairperson of the 1 st level GRC		

Service Standards for manual/ online Channel			
Level of addressing grievance	Action to be taken	Responsibility	Timeline
			GRC 2 nd level

8. Service Standards

Level	Responsible Entity	Resolution Timeline
Field / Site Level	GRC-I	7 days
Cluster / CPIU Level	GRC-II	15 days
PIU Level	GRC-III	15 days

9. Feedback Mechanism

Upon closure of a grievance, feedback shall be obtained from the complainant to assess satisfaction regarding transparency, fairness, responsiveness, and timeliness. Feedback may be collected through forms, phone calls, or personal interaction.

10. Training on GRM

A comprehensive set of trainings on the GRM will be designed covering the PIU and CPIUs at the State and District. The training will be designed cascading from the PIU that trains Cluster level and district level implementing units officials as part of the Social Safeguards Training. Table below depicts the training schedule/requirement on the GRM:

Type of training	Level of training	Participants	Timeline
2-day Orientation on Social Safeguards and Gender including Grievance Redressal Mechanism	State level	Key officials of PIUs	Y1, Y3
	District level	Key officials from district.	
1-day sensitization workshop on Social Safeguards and Gender including Grievance Redressal Mechanism	State level	Service Providers (SPs)	
1-day sensitization workshop for BDC on GRM.	Field level	BDMC, Beel animators	Y1, Y3, Y5

11. Documentation, Monitoring, and Reporting

The Project Management Information System (PMIS) shall serve as the central platform for GRM monitoring. All grievances shall be entered, tracked, and periodically analyzed.

Key monitoring indicators include:

- Number and type of grievances received

- Resolution rate within stipulated timelines
- Average resolution time
- Number of escalated cases
- Feedback and satisfaction ratings

Aggregated GRM performance reports will be prepared on a quarterly basis, and shall be publicly disclosed at a vernacular language during the annual general body meeting of the BDC.

In addition proactive Information Dissemination and GRM awareness shall be promoted through:

- Information, Communication and Education(IEC) materials (sample at Annexure-VI) in local languages
- Display boards at sites and offices
- Website disclosure

12. Conflict of Interest Management

Grievances involving potential conflict of interest at district or CPIU level shall be directly handled by PIU/PMU and accordingly escalated to PIU/PMU for independent review and resolution, following defined timelines.

13. Gender-Based Violence and SEA/SH

Complaints related to Gender-Based Violence (GBV) or Sexual Exploitation and Abuse/Sexual Harassment (SEA/SH) shall be immediately referred to the Internal Complaints Committee (ICC) of the PIU/CPIU/DFDO/BDC offices (depending on the location where the incident occurred) for appropriate action, in accordance with the provisions of the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013. The referral and subsequent handling of such complaints shall strictly ensure confidentiality, protection from retaliation, and a survivor-centered approach, while following the prescribed procedures for redressal.

14. Arbitration and Appeal

If the complainant remains dissatisfied, the grievance may be escalated to PMU for further review. The complainant retains the right to seek legal remedies at any stage.

15. Access to Legal Remedies and ADB Accountability Mechanism

The GRM does not preclude access to judicial remedies. In unresolved cases, affected persons may also approach the ADB Accountability Mechanism after making a good-faith effort to resolve the issue through the project GRM.

16. Confidentiality and Record Keeping

All grievance records shall be securely maintained at CPIU and PIU levels with strict confidentiality and periodic reporting to ADB.

Annexures:

Annexure-I: Sample Grievance Registration Form

Annexure-II: Grievance Register Format (Field / BDC Level)

Annexure-III: Grievance Acknowledgment Slip

Annexure-IV: Grievance Resolution Record Sheet (GRC Use)

Annexure-V: Complainant Feedback Form (Post-Resolution)

Annexure-VI: Short SOP – Grievance Redressal Mechanism (GRM) for Field Staff & BDCs – SWIFT
Project

Annexure-VII: Leaflet on GRMS of SWIFT

Annexure-I

Sample Grievance Registration Form

The SWIFT Project welcomes complaints, suggestions, queries and comments regarding project implementation. We encourage persons with grievance to provide their name and contact information to enable us to get in touch with you for clarification and feedback. Should you choose to include your personal details but want that information to remain confidential, please inform us by writing/typing *(CONFIDENTIAL)* above your name. Thank you.

Date		Place of registration	
Contact Information/Personal Details			
Name	Gender	Age	
Home Address			
Place			
Phone Number			
E-mail			
Complaint/Suggestion/Comment/Question Please provide the details (who, what, where and how) of your grievance below			
How do you want us to reach you for feedback or update on your comment/grievance?			

FOR OFFICIAL USE ONLY	
Registered by: (Name of Official registering grievance)	
Mode of communication: Note/Letter Email/Verbal/Telephonic	
Reviewed by: (Names/Positions of Official(s) reviewing grievance)	
Action Taken:	
Whether Action Taken Disclosed:	Yes
Means of Disclosure:	

Annexure-II

Grievance Register Format (Field / BDC Level) (If possible this should be through an online GRM System)

1. **Project:** Assam Sustainable Wetland & Integrated Fisheries Transformation (SWIFT) Project
2. **Location (Beel/Village/CPIU):**
3. **Maintained by:**
4. **Reporting Month:**

Sl. No.	Date Received	Grievance ID No.	Name of Complainant (or Anonymous)	Gender	Category (tick)	Contact Details	Village/Beel	Brief Description of Grievance	Mode (Verbal/Written /Phone/Box/On line)	Sensitive Case (Y/N)	Forwarded to GRC Date	GRC Level (I/II/III)	Action Taken	Date Resolved	Status (Open/Resolved /Escalated)	Escalated To	Remarks

Grievance Category Codes (for quick entry):

- 1 = Beneficiary selection
- 2 = Benefit/payment issue
- 3 = Construction/work quality
- 4 = Environmental impact
- 5 = Social impact
- 6 = Staff behavior/misconduct
- 7 = Inclusion/exclusion
- 8 = Suggestion/feedback
- 9 = Other

Annexure-III

Grievance Acknowledgment Slip

SWIFT Project – Grievance Acknowledgment

1. Grievance ID No:
2. Date of Receipt:
3. Received from:
4. Village/Beel:
5. Mode of Receipt (tick):
☐ Verbal ☐ Written ☐ Phone ☐ Drop Box ☐ Meeting ☐ Online
6. Brief Subject of Grievance:

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Your grievance has been registered and will be reviewed under the SWIFT Grievance Redressal Mechanism.

Expected Time for Initial Decision: Within 7 days (field level)

You may contact the following person for status:

Name:

Designation:

Phone:

Signature of Receiving Officer:

Name & Designation:

Annexure-IV

Grievance Resolution Record Sheet (GRC Use)

1. **GRC Level:** I / II / III
2. **Meeting Date:**
3. **Grievance ID:**
4. Complainant Name/ID:
5. Location:
6. Summary of Grievance:.....
.....
.....
.....
7. Verification Conducted By:
8. Date of Field Verification:
9. Findings:

10. Decision of GRC:
 - ☐ Accepted
 - ☐ Partially Accepted
 - ☐ Not Accepted
 - ☐ Referred/Escalated
11. Corrective Action Ordered:
 - Responsible Person/Unit:
 - Time Limit for Action:
 - Date of Closure:
 - Signatures of GRC Members:
 1.
 2.
 3.

Annexure-V
Complainant Feedback Form (Post-Resolution)
SWIFT Project – GRM Feedback Form

Grievance ID:

Date of Resolution:

Location:

1. Were you informed about the GRM process?
☐ Yes ☐ No
2. Was your complaint heard respectfully? (If no, please specify why and how was expected to be heard?)
☐ Yes ☐ No
3. Was the response time reasonable? (If no, please specify the reason)
☐ Yes ☐ No
4. Are you satisfied with the resolution?
☐ Fully satisfied
☐ Partly satisfied
☐ Not satisfied
5. Transparency of process:
☐ Good ☐ Average ☐ Poor
6. Behavior of officials:
☐ Good ☐ Average ☐ Poor
7. Do you feel safe using the GRM again if needed?
☐ Yes ☐ No
8. Additional comments/suggestions:

Name (Optional):

Contact (Optional):

Collected by:

Designation:

Date:

Annexure-VI

Short SOP – Grievance Redressal Mechanism (GRM) of Assam SWIFT Project For Field Staff & BDCs – SWIFT Project

1. Purpose of this SOP

This SOP guides field staff and Beel Development Committees (BDCs) on how to receive, record, process, and forward grievances related to SWIFT Project activities in a timely, fair, and transparent manner.

All grievances must be handled seriously, respectfully, and confidentially.

2. Who Can Submit a Grievance

Field staff and BDCs must accept grievances from:

- Project Affected Persons (PAPs)
- Beel-dependent community members
- Beneficiaries and non-beneficiaries
- SHGs and fisher cooperatives
- Women, ST/SC households, vulnerable persons
- Any stakeholder affected by SWIFT activities

No fee is charged for submitting a grievance.

3. What Types of Issues Can Be Reported

Accept all project-related complaints, including:

- Beneficiary selection disputes
- Benefit-sharing issues
- Construction or work quality issues
- Environmental safeguard issues
- Social safeguard issues
- Misbehavior by staff or service providers
- Payment or livelihood support delays
- Exclusion of eligible persons
- Suggestions and feedback

Caution: Do NOT reject a complaint at field level unless clearly unrelated to the project.

4. Modes of Receiving Grievances at Field Level

Field staff / BDCs shall receive grievances through:

- Verbal complaint (in person)
- Written application
- Entry in grievance register
- Drop-box submission
- Phone message
- During meetings / consultations
- Online / Email (where available)

If verbal — **write it down and read it back to the complainant** for confirmation.

5. Immediate Actions (Within 2 Working Days)

When a grievance is received:

Step 1 — Register

Record in the **Grievance Register:**

- Date received

- Name (or anonymous)
- Contact details (if available)
- Village / beel name
- Complaint summary
- Category of grievance

Step 2 — Acknowledge

Give:

- Acknowledgment slip OR
- Tracking number / register serial number

Step 3 — Inform

Inform:

- BDC Facilitator
- Social Safeguards & Gender Coordinator (SSGC)
- DFDO / Nodal Officer (as applicable)

6. Field-Level Screening

BDC Facilitator + Beel Animator should check:

- Is it related to SWIFT project activities?
- Is it urgent (social and environmental issues, such as livelihood loss, safety risk, conflict)?
- Is it sensitive (GBV, harassment, corruption)?

Then forward to **Level-I GRC (Field Level)**.

7. Field-Level Resolution (Level-I GRC)

- GRC-I should meet quickly
- Hear the complainant (if willing)
- Verify facts locally
- Suggest corrective action

Timeline: Within 7 days of receipt

Record:

- Hearing date
- Decision taken
- Action assigned
- Closure date

8. When to Escalate

Forward to CPIU Level (Level-II GRC) if:

- Not resolved within 15 days
- Complainant not satisfied
- Issue involves multiple villages
- Conflict of interest at field level
- Allegation against field staff/BDC members

Forward through SSGC with full records.

9. Special Handling Cases

GBV / Sexual Harassment / SEA-SH

- Do NOT discuss publicly
- Do NOT record details in open register
- Immediately inform CPIU → PIU
- Refer to **Internal Complaints Committee (ICC)**
- Maintain strict confidentiality

Corruption / Fraud / Staff Misconduct

- Mark as **Sensitive**
- Forward to CPIU/PIU directly
- Do not attempt local settlement

10. Communication with Complainant

Field staff must:

- Treat complainant respectfully
- Never threaten or discourage complaint
- Never promise illegal favors
- Inform expected timeline
- Share decision after GRC action

If rejected — explain reasons clearly.

11. Record Keeping at Beel Level

Maintain:

- Grievance Register
- Acknowledgment slips copy
- GRC meeting notes
- Action taken record
- Escalation record

Registers must be available for project review.

12. Monthly Reporting

Beel Animator / BDC Facilitator shall submit monthly summary to CPIU:

- Number received
- Number resolved
- Number escalated
- Pending cases
- Sensitive cases (separate note)

13. Behavior Standards for Field Staff & BDCs

Always:

- Listen patiently
- Remain neutral
- Avoid arguments
- Protect confidentiality
- Support vulnerable complainants
- Encourage women to speak

Never:

- Refuse to register a valid complaint
- Demand money
- Reveal identity in sensitive cases
- Delay forwarding

14. Quick Timeline Summary

Action	Time Limit
• Register grievance	• Within 2 days
• Field GRC decision	• Within 7 days
• Escalation if unresolved	• By Day 7–15

Annexure-VII

Model Leaflet on GRMS of SWIFT Project

GRIEVANCE HELP & COMPLAINT SYSTEM (GRM)

Your Voice Matters

- If you have any complaint, problem, or suggestion about SWIFT Project activities — please tell us.
Your complaint will be recorded and addressed in a fair and time-bound manner.
- **No fee is required. Complaints can be given by anyone.**

WHAT CAN YOU COMPLAIN ABOUT?

- You may complain about:
 - ✓ Beneficiary selection issues
 - ✓ Delay in benefits or payments
 - ✓ Work / construction quality
 - ✓ Environmental or social impacts
 - ✓ Misbehavior by staff or workers
 - ✓ Exclusion of eligible persons
 - ✓ Unfair treatment
 - ✓ Any project-related problem
 - ✓ Suggestions for improvement

HOW TO SUBMIT A COMPLAINT

- ✓ You can complain in any of these ways:
 - ☐ Tell the **Beel Animator / BDC Member**
 - ☐ Submit a written application
 - ☐ Write in the Grievance Register
 - ☐ Drop in Complaint Box
 - ☐ Phone / Message project staff
 - ☐ Online / Email (where available)

You may also complain without giving your name.

WHAT WILL HAPPEN NEXT?

- Your complaint will be registered
- You will receive a complaint number
- Field Grievance Committee will review
- Decision normally within **7 days**
- If not resolved — it is sent to higher level
- You will be informed of the action taken.

CONFIDENTIAL & SENSITIVE COMPLAINTS

- Complaints about harassment, exploitation, or serious misconduct are handled **confidentially** through a special process.

LOCAL CONTACT DETAILS (TO BE FILLED BY OFFICE)

Beel Animator: _____
 Phone: _____
 BDC Facilitator: _____
 Phone: _____
 District Fisheries Office: _____
 Phone: _____



GRIEVANCE HELP & COMPLAINT SYSTEM (GRM)

Your Voice Matters

No fees. Anyone can complain.

What Can You Complain About?



Suggestions

How to Submit a Complaint

**Online / Email**

What Happens Next?

4

Higher Level:
if Needed



Harassment or Serious Issues Kept Secret



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